financial assistance of Rs 12,000 in three instalments before and after delivery. Similarly, under the sheep distribution scheme, beneficiaries have got nothing since 2018 despite paying their 25 per cent share. The same goes for fee reimbursements and scholarships to some 1.3 million students, which are pending for two years. Ironically, on the very day of the party plenary, the Supreme Court put the Telangana government in the dock for cancelling over 1.9 million public distribution system (PDS) ration cards as "bogus". Asserting that access to basic nutrition through PDS is a statutory right, the apex court noted that the cards were cancelled "unilaterally" without giving the card-holders an opportunity to present their case. Justice L. Nageswara Rao directed the state to conduct a drive to verify the credentials of the card-holders whose names were removed.

BROKEN PROMISES

The TRS government is also saddled with a litany of pre-poll promises made in 2014 and 2018 that it has been unable to keep. These include appointing a Dalit as CM, a monthly dole of Rs 3,016 for the unemployed, allotting three acres of land to every Dalit family, and 12 per cent reservation for Muslims and 10 per cent for Scheduled Tribes in education and employment. Expenditure on irrigation—especially on the Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Scheme, which KCR tom-toms as the world's largest multipurpose project of its ilk—has been extraordinarily high and the accounts are yet to be presented for audit. Rival parties allege that several TRS leaders in cahoots with contractors have collected huge kickbacks. Now, in the wake of a slew of welfare schemes and cash transfers, the state faces a funds crunch. Moreover, KCR announced in March that 80,039 vacancies in government jobs are to be filled and the services of 11,103 contractual employees regularised. With the state government doing little to create wealth, it is relying on loans and the sale of high-value land to fund welfare schemes and pay salaries to employees. The latest report by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) points at glaring flaws in financial management in the state.

Many are also peeved that the party has turned away several of the real flag-bearers of the second separate statehood campaign that began in 2000. Coming together under the banner of the Telangana Jana Samithi (TJS), they allege that KCR has made a mockery of governance. "Is there any other instance in independent India where the governor (Tamilisai Soundararajan) has alleged that the chief minister is behaving like a dictator? Where else do you have a CM who does not go to the state secretariat and expects senior bureaucrats to attend meetings at his official residence?" asks TJS vice-president P.L. Vishweshwar Rao, pointing out that key sectors like education and health have not got their due because of the heavy expenditure on irrigation.

CRORES IN ITS COFFERS

With assets worth Rs 1,000 crore, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) is among the richest regional political parties in the country. Besides immovable assets, including offices in Hyderabad, the districts and one coming up in Delhi, the party is flush with money, enough to fund a national push. The cash component of its total asset base is Rs 861 crore, including fixed deposits of Rs 451 crore and funds from electoral bonds pledged with the State Bank of India and the Bank of Baroda. The party earns Rs 3.84 crore every month as interest on the fixed deposits. The accrued interest in its current account is Rs 24.7 crore.

TRS chief and Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao is confident that much more can be raised with ease. "If every worker or leader contributes Rs 1,000, the party can raise Rs 600 crore (from 6 million members), which can come in handy for our foray into national politics," says KCR.

At the same time, the BJP and the Congress can mobilise a lot more in terms of financial resources if they wish. A report by the Association for Democratic Reforms, a poll reforms advocacy group, based on an assets-liabilities analysis of political parties in financial year 2019-20, suggested the BJP is the richest party in the country, with declared assets worth Rs 4,847.8 crore, followed by the Bahujan Samaj Party with Rs 698.3 crore and the Congress with Rs 588.2 crore. Among the regional parties, the Samajwadi Party declared the highest assets (Rs 563.5 crore) in the same period, followed by the TRS (Rs 301.5 crore) and the AIADMK (Rs 267.6 crore). Some of that will likely be flowing like water in the near future.



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